

The Shocking FAILURE 4 A CHAIN OF LAPSES

The nodal agency, National Disaster Management Authority, wasted crucial time in responding to what was clearly a flood of Biblical proportions



WHY THEY WERE FOUND WANTING: Manmohan (right) with Sonia and Nitish on a visit to the flood-affected areas in Bihar

CENTRE

■ **National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA):** It lays down policies, plans and guidelines for disaster management and coordinates enforcement and implementation of response to disasters. By the time NDMA Chairman Prime Minister Manmohan Singh visited Bihar and announced a national disaster on August 28, nearly 10 valuable days had been lost.

■ **National Executive Committee (NEC):** The NDMA's executive coordinates responses in an event of a disaster and comprising 15 secretaries of relevant ministries, was supplanted by the older National Crisis Management Committee (NCMC) headed by the Cabinet Secretary. The NCMC moved in only after the prime minister visited Bihar.

chief minister. In his defence, Kumar says: "The devastation and sudden change in the river's course created a unique situation. There is no mechanism available in the country to tackle such a crisis." But his opponents lashed out at him. "Behaving like a heartless dictator he threw millions into the watery graves. He must resign, he must be tried for genocide," senior RJD leader Jagdanand said. RJD supremo Lalu Prasad Yadav, who toured the area along with the prime minister, says people affected by the flood are fleeing Bihar and taking shelter in other states because there is no governmental help. "This is worse than the scene during the Partition. What is this Government for?" asked Lalu, who ordered the Railways to ferry flood victims free of cost to anywhere they wanted to go. As scathing was Union Minister Ram Vilas Paswan, also an arch rival of Kumar. Paswan said, "There is no administration worth its name in Bihar. The entire state is reeling under the flood. And the Government has terribly

What needs to BE DONE

- With rains likely to subside only in end-September, a national effort needs to be mounted to provide relief to the three million people likely to be affected.
- Best engineering brains called in to see whether breach could be repaired or the overflow lessened immediately.
- With property records damaged and houses destroyed, the state has to ensure reconstruction begins and disputes settled.
- With crops destroyed, alternative means of employment need to be found for the displaced. Temporary schools need to be set up for their children.